

The railways has always had to devise ways to stay efficient in the face of an ever-increasing volume of workload. The 1920s introduced mechanization through punch card equipment for data processing, which continued to be in operation for many years post-Independence. This soon proved to be limited in its capacity when the railways witnessed a significant increase in traffic and statistical data. The system transitioned to unit-record equipment in the early 1960s, but were phased out within a few years. The idea of a comprehensive management information system first came up around this time, wherein all subsystems could be integrated, for quick access to data, which would help in faster decision-making. This required improvement in the data processing equipment.

Thus, electronic computers made their way into the system in the mid-1960s. Nine zonal railways, three production units, and the Railway Board office were given second-generation computers, the IBM 1401s. Passenger revenue, financial management, and goods accounting were computerized. Soon, the further increase in traffic necessitated upgradation. By the mid-1980s, second-generation computers gave way to third- and fourth-generation ones, in tandem with the Seventh Five Year Plan (1985-90), which laid emphasis on modern technology. During this phase, the Passenger Reservation System (PRS), the Freight Operations Information System (FOIS), locomotive sheds, stores, workshops, and divisions were all brought under the computerization scheme.